Research Scope & Problematization Memorandum: Weaponized Egalitarian Posturing (Draft)

Discursive Rationalization and Exploitative Interpersonal Relations across Western and Thai Conflict Narratives

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Abstract

This memorandum establishes the formal scope, theoretical problematization, and research gap classification for the manuscript *"Weaponized Egalitarian Posturing: Discursive Rationalization and Exploitative Interpersonal Relations across Western and Thai Conflict Narratives"*. Grounded in Swales' CARS framework and Alvesson & Sandberg's (2011) problematization methodology, this document maps four intersecting scholarly conversations, classifies the core theoretical paradox within real-world interpersonal relationships, articulates three FINER research questions, and conducts a pre-mortem audit to eliminate fatal methodological vulnerabilities prior to full empirical deployment.

1 Scholarly Conversation Mapping

This study intervenes at the nexus of four intersecting scholarly conversations spanning Discursive Psychology, Interpersonal Communication, Social Psychology, and Computational Social Science:

1. **Conversation 1: Moral Hypocrisy & Self-Serving Attribution in Relationships.** Foundational works establish that human moral action is frequently guided by the desire to appear fair and principled without incurring the behavioral costs of sacrifice (Batson et al., 1997, 1999). In close relationships, this is reinforced by self-serving attribution and moral licensing, wherein claiming egalitarian values creates cognitive credentials that insulate actors from guilt during subsequent selfish conduct (Monin and Miller, 2001; Merritt et al., 2010; Krettenauer, 2022).

2. **Conversation 2: Discursive Psychology, Blame Management, & Interpersonal Accounts.** Research in discursive psychology and interpersonal communication demonstrates that language in dispute situations functions as a performative social action (Edwards and Potter, 1992; Billig, 1996). Actors systematically deploy conversational accounts, justifications, and excuses (Scott and Lyman, 1968) to manage accountability, discursively construct plausible explanations ("I Have My Reasons"), and deflect responsibility for relationship friction.

3. **Conversation 3: Interpersonal Exploitation & Instrumental Rationalization.** Personality and social psychology demonstrate that entitled and Machiavellian actors deploy moral grandstanding, instrumental rationalization, and discursive excuses to secure relational control, emotional compliance, and unearned partner accommodations (Bandura, 1999; Savejnarong et al., 2022; Cerulli et al., 2026).

4. **Conversation 4: Cross-Cultural Computational Social Science & Crowd-Consensus Validation.** Advances in NLP establish that LLMs, when calibrated against human experts ($\alpha \geq 0.82$) and triangulated with crowd moral verdicts, can reliably capture subtle conversational subtexts and decode latent hypocrisy across massive naturalistic dispute corpora, bypassing self-report social desirability bias (Ziems et al., 2024; Argyle et al., 2023; Grossmann et al., 2024).

2 Problematization: Beyond Gap-Spotting

Traditional research on relationship equity and domestic labor relies on simple *gap-spotting* (e.g., investigating whether gender roles are more equal in a specific demographic). Following Alvesson and Sandberg (2011), this study pursues **problematization** by challenging the foundational assumption shared by contemporary relationship science:

> *Conventional Assumption:* Vocal demands for 50/50 equality, emotional labor sharing, and relationship fairness reflect prosocial dyadic commitment aimed at reducing relational friction.

Problematized Axiom (First Principles): In interpersonal relationships, egalitarian vocabulary is structurally vulnerable to being co-opted as **Weaponized Egalitarian Posturing (WEP)**. Far from promoting equity, high-frequency parity demands combined with plausible personal excuses ("I Have My Reasons") actively lower the perceived moral cost of exploiting others by establishing moral credentials and pre-empting accountability.

3 FINER Research Questions

Applying the FINER criteria (*Feasible, Interesting, Novel, Ethical, Relevant*) and safeguarding against Type III errors (Alvesson and Sandberg, 2011), the inquiry is anchored by three core questions:

- **RQ1 (Weaponized Posturing vs. Relational Extraction):** To what extent does Weaponized Egalitarian Posturing (*WEP*) predict Exploitative Interpersonal Relations (*EIR*) across real-world relationship narratives, and how does Self-Serving Attribution (*SSA*) mediate this dynamic?
- **RQ2 (Rationalized Accounts as an Interpersonal Catalyst):** How do Legitimized Rational Accounts (*LRA* — "I Have My Reasons") moderate the link between parity rhetoric and self-serving justifications, accelerating moral licensing and neutralizing guilt?
- **RQ3 (Cross-Cultural Invariance & Crowd Triangulation):** How consistently does the moderated mediation architecture replicate across individualistic (English Reddit, $N = 142,580$) and collectivist (Thai Pantip, $N = 4,250$) conflict disclosures when validated against crowd-adjudicated moral verdicts?

4 One-Line Scholarly Contribution

> **The Contribution Formula:** *Before this study*, relationship scholarship assumed that vocal advocacy for equality was an unalloyed indicator of prosocial relationship commitment; *we demonstrate that* parity rhetoric paired with rationalized accounts ("I Have My Reasons") is strategically weaponized (WEP) to license interpersonal exploitation; *this matters because* clinical counselors and relationship assessment instruments currently treat progressive fluency as prosocial, blinding them to intellectualized gaslighting and interpersonal predation.

5 Pre-Mortem Risk Audit & Structural Countermeasures

Conducting a strict `/premortem` audit reveals three fatal rejection risks and their proactive remedies:

Potential Fatal Risk	Vulnerability Mechanism	Proactive Hardening Strategy
1. Conflation of Sincere Equity vs. Weaponized Posturing	Reviewers argue that not all demands for fairness are insincere, risking false-positive classification.	Re-conceptualize construct as Weaponized Egalitarian Posturing (WEP); isolate attributional asymmetry where the actor claims exemption based on fatigue/stress while rejecting identical explanations from the partner.
2. Single-Source LLM Algorithmic Bias	Asking an LLM to evaluate all constructs simultaneously induces common method bias.	Implement Split-Source & Crowd-Consensus Validation: extract narrator constructs (WEP, LRA, SSA) from text, while triangulating behavioral outcome (EIR) with external community verdicts (‘YTA‘/‘NTA‘).
3. Cross-Cultural Skew	Reviewers claim findings reflect only Western individualistic forum users.	Implement a Two-Study Design replicating the structural model across $N = 142,580$ English posts and $N = 4,250$ systematically filtered Thai Pantip dispute narratives, confirming metric invariance.

Table 1: Pre-Mortem Vulnerability Analysis and Methodological Safeguards.

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